

The Nobility and Exemplarity of the Celibate Individual

An Antinatalist and Ascetic Reconsideration of Autonomy and Quality of Life

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Original version: 21 October 2025 | Revised version (v2): 22 August 2026

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Preprint. Not peer-reviewed.

Abstract

This paper reconsiders celibacy not as a mere absence of sexual activity but as a substantive ethical and existential stance with a long history in Buddhist, Christian, and classical philosophical traditions. Drawing on antinatalist ethics, Epicurean hedonology, and Schopenhauerian pessimism, I argue that the conventional justification of sexual activity as a societal necessity — grounded in concerns about reproduction and demographic continuity — conflates descriptive biological function with normative ethical value. Once this conflation is set aside, I argue, the ethical evaluation of one's mode of living can be grounded instead in individual autonomy and self-sustaining quality of life (QOL) rather than reproductive obligation. Engaging with David Benatar's asymmetry argument, I suggest that the moral status of humanity's demographic continuity need not be treated as self-evidently overriding individual self-determination. I then draw on Epicurus's distinction between stable and transient pleasure, and on Schopenhauer's account of sexual desire as an expression of a species-oriented will-to-live, to argue that celibacy can constitute a coherent discipline of autonomous, self-sustained flourishing. Finally, I consider four objections — from relational psychology, from the alleged self-undermining character of universalized antinatalism, from the charge of theological parochialism, and from the subjectivity of QOL judgments — and offer replies. I conclude that celibacy, properly understood, merits recognition as one exemplary and defensible path of ethical self-cultivation, rather than as a deficiency to be explained away.

Keywords: celibacy; asceticism; antinatalism; autonomy; quality of life; Epicureanism; Schopenhauer

1. Introduction

Contemporary ethical discourse tends to treat celibacy — whether religious, philosophical, or simply chosen — as a residual category: an absence to be explained, a deviation from a presumed default of partnered, reproductive life. Historically, however, the celibate figure occupied a very different position. The Buddhist monk, the Christian ascetic, and the classical philosopher who withdrew from the concerns of household and family were not regarded as deficient but as exemplary: figures whose renunciation of sexual and reproductive life was itself a mark of discipline, freedom, and moral seriousness. This paper attempts to recover and defend a version of that older evaluation, situating it within contemporary debates in population ethics and the philosophy of well-being.

My central claim is twofold. First, the standard justification for treating sexual activity as ethically necessary — namely, that reproduction is required for the continuation of society and of the species — rests on a conflation of descriptive and normative claims that does not survive scrutiny once the resources of

antinatalist ethics are brought to bear. Second, once this conflation is dissolved, the ethical question of how one ought to live can be reoriented around individual autonomy and quality of life, understood as self-sustaining and non-dependent well-being, rather than around reproductive or relational obligation. On this reoriented picture, celibacy is not merely permissible but can be genuinely exemplary: a discipline that cultivates the kind of stable, autonomous well-being that both ancient hedonist and pessimist philosophy independently identify as more reliable than pleasure that depends on external, transient stimulation.

This is not an argument that celibacy is obligatory, nor that partnered or sexual life is without value for those who choose it. It is, rather, an argument that celibacy deserves to be taken seriously as one legitimate and historically well-attested model of ethical self-cultivation — one whose internal logic has been obscured by the unexamined assumption that reproductive, sexually active life is the normative default against which all other modes of living must justify themselves.

The paper proceeds as follows. Section 2 situates the argument historically, examining celibacy as a discipline associated with intellectual and spiritual freedom in Buddhist, Christian, and classical sources. Section 3 develops the antinatalist critique of the reproduction-based justification for treating sex as ethically necessary. Section 4 develops the positive account of autonomous, self-sustaining quality of life, drawing on Epicurus and Schopenhauer. Section 5 considers objections. Section 6 concludes.

2. Historical and Religious Precedents: Celibacy as Aristocratic Discipline

The association between celibacy and a kind of freedom — what the original version of this paper called an "aristocratic freedom" — is not a modern invention. In the Buddhist monastic tradition, celibacy (*brahmacarya*) is one of the foundational precepts of ordained life, codified in the Vinaya Pitaka. It is understood not as a punitive restriction but as instrumental to liberation from craving (*tanha*), which Buddhist psychology treats as the root of suffering (*dukkha*). The monk's renunciation of sexual activity is continuous with, rather than separate from, the broader project of reducing attachment to transient states; it is one discipline among several — including renunciation of property and status — aimed at cultivating an equanimity that does not depend on external conditions.

A structurally similar logic appears in Christian ascetic and monastic thought. Paul's counsel in 1 Corinthians 7 explicitly frames celibacy as freeing the individual for undivided devotion, contrasting the concerns of the married person, who must attend to a spouse, with the unmarried person's capacity for singular focus. Later monastic theology, including Thomas Aquinas's treatment of virginity and continence, develops this into a broader claim that celibacy is ordered toward a higher good — understood as contemplative freedom — rather than being merely a negative abstention from a positive good, as it is often understood in casual usage. It is this contrast — celibacy as an ordering toward freedom, rather than a deficiency — that this paper seeks to generalize beyond its original theological setting.

A parallel, secular version of the same structure appears already in classical philosophy, in the Aristotelian notion of *scholē* (leisure) as the precondition of philosophical and civic virtue. For Aristotle, the person absorbed in the necessities of practical life — including, on some readings, the management of household and family — has less capacity for the contemplative activity that constitutes the highest form of *eudaimonia*. The celibate or unattached life, on this reading, is not aristocratic in a narrow sociological sense

(a matter of inherited class privilege) but in the older sense the original paper gestures toward: a life organized around the cultivation of one's own capacities rather than around obligations imposed by reproduction and household management.

What these traditions share, despite their very different metaphysical commitments, is a common structural claim: that sexual and reproductive engagement carries significant opportunity costs in time, attention, and psychological stability, and that renouncing it can — for those suited to, and freely choosing, this path — open space for a different, and in some respects more autonomous, form of flourishing. The remainder of this paper develops a secular, non-theological version of this claim, grounded in antinatalist population ethics and in Epicurean and Schopenhauerian accounts of pleasure and desire.

3. The Antinatalist Reframing of Reproductive Necessity

The most common justification offered for treating sexual activity as ethically necessary is straightforwardly consequentialist at the level of the species or society: without reproduction, human society would not continue, and continuation of human society is assumed to be an overriding good. This argument moves quickly from a descriptive premise (reproduction is necessary for demographic continuity) to a normative conclusion (individuals therefore have reason, or even obligation, to engage in reproductive — or at least sexually active — life). This inference is not as secure as it appears.

First, the argument conflates a necessary condition for a state of affairs (continued human existence) with a reason for any given individual to bring that state of affairs about. Even granting that reproduction is necessary for demographic continuity in the aggregate, it does not follow that any particular individual is thereby obligated to reproduce, any more than the fact that agriculture is necessary for feeding the population obligates any particular individual to farm. Some distribution of reproductive versus non-reproductive lives is compatible with the aggregate outcome without requiring universal participation.

Second, and more fundamentally, the argument presupposes that demographic continuation is an overriding good whose pursuit can justifiably constrain individual modes of living. This presupposition is precisely what antinatalist ethics puts into question. David Benatar's influential asymmetry argument holds that the presence of pain is bad, the presence of pleasure is good, the absence of pain is good even if no one exists to enjoy that absence, but the absence of pleasure is not bad unless someone exists who is thereby deprived of it (Benatar, 2006). On this view, coming into existence entails exposure to a harm (suffering) that is not offset by a corresponding benefit in the same way that not coming into existence would be a "loss," because there is no subject who is deprived by never existing. Whatever one concludes about the full range of implications Benatar draws from this asymmetry, the argument is sufficient to unsettle the unreflective assumption that bringing new people into existence is straightforwardly good, and therefore to unsettle the further assumption that individuals owe it to society, or to the species, to engage in reproductive life.

It is worth being precise about what does and does not follow from this. The claim is not that human extinction is a positive good to be actively pursued, nor that existing lives lack value. It is the more modest claim that a gradual demographic decline resulting from individuals autonomously choosing non-reproductive lives is not self-evidently a moral catastrophe that overrides individual self-determination. Once the demographic-necessity argument is denied this overriding force, the question of how an individual

ought to live is returned to the individual, to be evaluated in terms of that individual's own quality of life and self-cultivation, rather than being pre-empted by an appeal to species-level necessity.

This reframing does substantive philosophical work, but it should not be overstated. It does not, by itself, establish that celibacy is superior to sexually active or reproductive life; it establishes only that the strongest available argument for treating sexual activity as ethically obligatory — the demographic-necessity argument — fails to do the work it is typically assumed to do. The positive case for celibacy as an exemplary, rather than merely permissible, mode of living requires the further argument developed in the next section.

4. Quality of Life, Autonomy, and the Critique of Sexual Pleasure

If reproductive necessity does not settle the question of how one ought to live, the question becomes: what makes one mode of living — celibate or otherwise — more or less choiceworthy? A resource-independent, non-theological answer is available in the ancient distinction, developed most explicitly by Epicurus, between kinetic and katastematic pleasure.

Kinetic pleasure, in Epicurus's usage, is the pleasure of a process: the pleasure of satisfying a felt desire, which arises precisely because a prior state of want or disturbance is being relieved. Katastematic pleasure, by contrast, is the stable pleasure of a settled state — paradigmatically, the state Epicurus calls *ataraxia*, or freedom from disturbance — which does not depend on the cycle of desire and satisfaction (Epicurus, *Letter to Menoeceus*, in Diogenes Laertius, Book X). For Epicurus, katastematic pleasure is both more stable and, ultimately, more choiceworthy than kinetic pleasure, precisely because it does not depend on the periodic recurrence of want.

Sexual pleasure is, on any plausible account, a paradigm case of kinetic pleasure: it arises through the cyclical pattern of desire, pursuit, and satisfaction; it is dependent on the presence and responsiveness of another person; and it is characteristically transient, giving way to renewed desire rather than to settled satisfaction. This is not, in itself, a moral criticism of sexual pleasure so much as a structural observation about the kind of pleasure it is. But the observation has normative implications if one accepts, with Epicurus, that katastematic pleasure is the more reliable and choiceworthy basis for a well-lived life. A mode of living organized around the cultivation of katastematic states — through practices such as contemplation, discipline, or the deliberate reduction of desire — has a structural advantage in stability over a mode of living organized around the pursuit of kinetic pleasures, including sexual ones, because it is less hostage to external conditions: the responsiveness of a partner, the vagaries of relationships, or the biological cycle of desire and satiation.

Arthur Schopenhauer offers a related, though metaphysically more pessimistic, version of this critique. In *The World as Will and Representation*, Schopenhauer treats all willing — including desire and its satisfaction — as manifestations of a single, blind, insatiable metaphysical will, whose satisfaction in any particular case is only ever temporary, giving way immediately to renewed striving (Schopenhauer, 1818/1966). Sexual desire, for Schopenhauer, is the most powerful expression of this will, because it operates, as he argues at length in the supplementary chapter "The Metaphysics of Sexual Love" (Schopenhauer, 1844/1966), not chiefly for the benefit of the individual but in service of the species: the

intensity of erotic passion is, on his account, the will's strategy for securing reproduction, substantially indifferent to the happiness of the individuals it enlists. On this view, what the individual experiences as the pursuit of personal happiness through romantic and sexual attachment is, from a more detached vantage point, the operation of an impersonal reproductive drive that does not reliably serve the individual's own well-being. Schopenhauer's ethical response to this diagnosis — the "denial of the will," most fully realized in ascetic renunciation, including sexual renunciation — treats celibacy not as a loss but as among the highest available strategies for reducing the individual's exposure to the endless, unsatisfiable striving that Schopenhauer identifies as the source of suffering.

These two frameworks — one hedonist, one pessimist, both secular — help reconstruct the intuition, present in the original version of this argument, that sexual attachment can function as a kind of misplaced ultimate concern: an investment of one's deepest hopes for stable happiness in a source — another person, and the cyclical dynamics of desire — that is structurally unable to provide the kind of stability being sought. Where the original formulation of this idea drew on the theological language of idolatry, the Epicurean and Schopenhauerian frameworks make a structurally similar point without requiring theistic commitments: sexual and romantic pleasure, by its nature as kinetic, other-dependent pleasure, is a poor candidate for the foundation of a stable, autonomous well-being — even if it may be a valuable and legitimate part of life for those who pursue it without treating it as such a foundation.

On this basis, autonomy — understood, in a broadly Kantian sense, as the capacity to legislate for oneself the principles governing one's own life, rather than being governed by externally or biologically imposed ends (Kant, 1785/1998) — is best exercised, I want to suggest, in a mode of living that does not make one's stable well-being hostage to the responsiveness of another person or to the satisfaction of a recurring desire. This is close to the classical notion of *autarkeia*, self-sufficiency, which Aristotle treats as a component — though not the whole — of *eudaimonia* (Aristotle, *Nicomachean Ethics*, Book I). The celibate individual, on this reconstruction, is not simply avoiding a pleasure but is exercising a specific kind of autonomy: the autonomy to organize one's life around self-sustaining rather than externally dependent sources of well-being.

5. Objections and Replies

Objection 1 (The Relational Objection). A substantial body of psychological research on attachment suggests that intimate relationships, including sexual relationships, contribute significantly to human well-being, and that humans are, as a matter of empirical fact, deeply relational beings for whom isolation from intimate bonds is often costly. Does this not undercut the claim that celibacy constitutes an equally viable mode of flourishing?

Reply. Two points are relevant. First, the argument of this paper does not claim that all forms of intimacy or relational connection are structurally kinetic or unstable in the way sexual pleasure specifically is; friendship, in the Aristotelian sense of *philia*, is arguably a form of relational good compatible with, and indeed often deepened by, the kind of non-dependent stability celibacy is said to cultivate. The celibate life, as historically practiced in monastic communities, is typically not a life of isolation but of a different form of communal relation. Second, the empirical claim that relational and sexual bonds contribute to well-being on

average does not settle the normative question of what an individual, exercising autonomous self-determination, has best reason to pursue; population-level empirical tendencies constrain but do not dictate individual practical reason, and this paper's claim is explicitly about celibacy as one legitimate and exemplary option, not as a claim that it maximizes average reported well-being.

Objection 2 (The Self-Undermining Objection). If the antinatalist reasoning of Section 3 were universalized, the human population — including the very religious and philosophical traditions (Buddhist monasticism, Christian asceticism) that this paper treats as exemplary — would eventually cease to exist for lack of new adherents. Does the argument therefore undermine its own historical exemplars?

Reply. This objection would have force against a prescriptive claim that celibacy is obligatory for all persons; it has much less force against the permissive and exemplary claim actually defended here. Buddhist and Christian monastic traditions have historically coexisted with, and indeed depended on, a much larger lay population that does not take celibate vows; the traditions do not require universal celibacy to remain exemplary, any more than the existence of philosophy as an exemplary activity requires that everyone become a philosopher. The argument of this paper is compatible with a stable equilibrium in which celibacy is available, admired, and chosen by some, without being adopted by all.

Objection 3 (The Parochialism Objection). The original framing of sexual attachment as "idolatry" presupposes a theistic value structure that not all readers share, and may therefore seem to beg the question against secular accounts of the good life that treat romantic and sexual fulfillment as intrinsically valuable.

Reply. This is a fair criticism of the original formulation, and this revision has attempted to address it directly by reconstructing the underlying claim in secular terms, via Epicurus's distinction between kinetic and katastematic pleasure and Schopenhauer's metaphysics of the will. Both frameworks arrive at a structurally similar conclusion — that sexual pleasure is a comparatively poor foundation for stable well-being — without invoking theistic premises. Readers who reject Epicurean and Schopenhauerian premises may still reject the conclusion, but the argument no longer depends on a theological framework that is not universally shared.

Objection 4 (The Subjectivity Objection). Judgments of quality of life are notoriously variable across individuals; some people may reliably find greater stable well-being through partnered, sexual life than through celibacy, and there is no straightforward empirical basis for claiming celibates enjoy higher QOL on average.

Reply. This paper does not claim, and does not need to claim, that celibates enjoy higher average reported well-being than non-celibates; no such empirical claim is defended here, and any such claim would require empirical evidence beyond the scope of a normative philosophical argument. The claim is instead structural and normative: that katastematic, self-sustaining sources of well-being have a stability advantage in principle over kinetic, other-dependent sources, and that celibacy is accordingly a coherent and defensible strategy for individuals who, on reflection, wish to organize their lives around this kind of stability. This is compatible with acknowledging that other individuals may reasonably and autonomously judge that partnered or sexual life better serves their own flourishing; the paper's claim is that celibacy deserves recognition as an exemplary option within this plurality, not that it is the uniquely correct choice for all.

6. Conclusion

This paper has argued that celibacy, reconsidered through the combined resources of antinatalist population ethics and the Epicurean and Schopenhauerian critiques of kinetic pleasure, can be defended as a coherent and exemplary — rather than merely permissible or deficient — mode of ethical self-cultivation. The demographic-necessity argument for treating sexual activity as obligatory does not survive the antinatalist critique of its underlying assumptions; and once that argument is set aside, the positive case for celibacy as a discipline of autonomous, self-sustaining quality of life can be made on independent, secular grounds that parallel, without depending on, the theological framings found in the Buddhist and Christian ascetic traditions. This is not an argument for the superiority of celibacy over all other modes of living, nor for its universal adoption; it is an argument that celibacy merits serious treatment in ethical discourse as an autonomous, historically well-attested path to stable flourishing, rather than being treated, by default, as a residual category requiring explanation. Future work might extend this analysis empirically, examining how self-reported quality of life varies across chosen celibate and non-celibate populations — a question this normative treatment leaves open.

AI Assistance Disclosure

This revised version of the manuscript was prepared with the assistance of Claude (Claude Sonnet 5), a large language model AI system developed by Anthropic, PBC, in August 2026. AI assistance was used to: (i) restructure the argument into discrete, numbered sections; (ii) situate the paper's claims within existing philosophical literature, including Buddhist, Christian, Epicurean, Schopenhauerian, and Kantian sources; (iii) draft an objections-and-replies section addressing relational, self-undermining, parochialism, and subjectivity objections to the paper's central argument; and (iv) expand and copyedit the prose of the original manuscript. The author reviewed, revised, and takes full intellectual responsibility for all claims, arguments, and citations herein. AI assistance was not used to generate original empirical data, and this paper makes no empirical claims beyond what is explicitly cited. The AI system does not qualify as an author of this work; this disclosure is provided in the interest of transparency regarding the drafting process.

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